Walls That Speak: Street Art, Murals, and Public Space Controversies in the Philippines

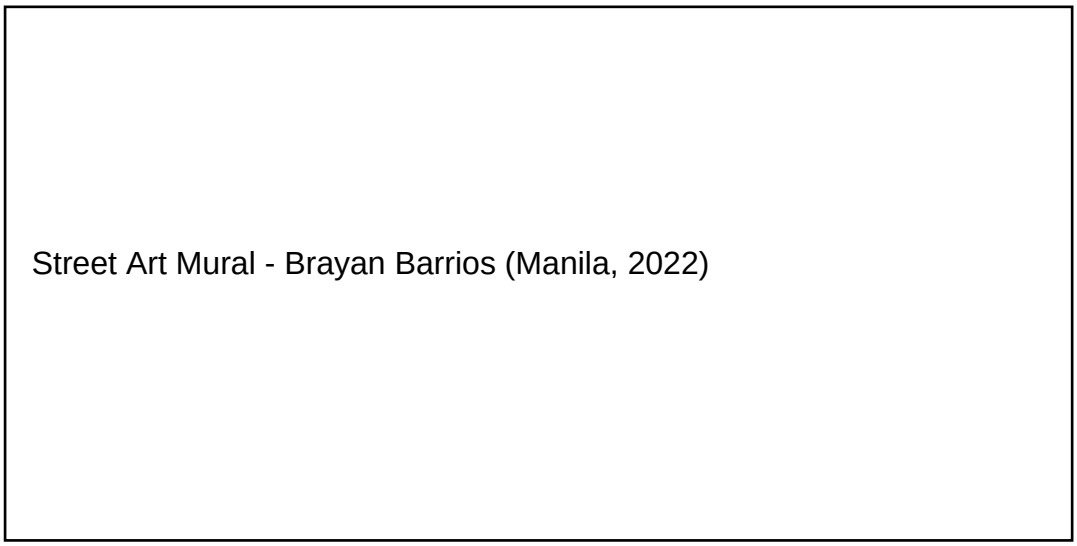
The concrete surfaces of our city—walls, underpasses, alleyways—have become more than mere physical boundaries. They are now canvases where voices that would otherwise be silenced demand to be seen. In Manila, Cebu, Baguio, and other urban centers, street art and murals are not just decoration. They are political manifestos, cultural celebrations, and sites of conflict.

Street art matters because it decentralizes art from galleries and elite spaces, making it accessible to everyday people. It gives marginalized communities visibility and is often one of the few ways to protest, memorialize, or critique power without entering formal systems. But these same murals often run into legal and political obstacles: defacement, erasure, censorship, or accusations of propaganda.

During Martial Law (1972–1981), clandestine graffiti and protest posters were used to mobilize dissent. After People Power, murals celebrated democracy, heroes, and collective history. More recently, projects like EDSA Project, “Kulay Cavite” mural festivals, and works by collectives such as ANDRES■Sugbo have revitalized public art culture.

Street art builds community identity and gives visibility to the underrepresented. But it also confronts societal norms—what is acceptable and what is blasphemy, what is safe and what is incendiary. Its imperfections (its temporary quality, its occasional controversy) are not flaws—they are part of its power.

I believe street art in the Philippines is a living narrative. It is raw, urgent, and embodied in public life. Its imperfections (its temporary quality, its occasional controversy) are not flaws—they are part of its power. Art should provoke, stir conscience, not just comfort.



Street Art Mural - Brayan Barrios (Manila, 2022)

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